below). As mentioned in Chapter 2, and argued more thoroughly in this chapter, more than a conventional capital city Firuzkuh was likely a royal *sard-sir* (summer) encampment – internally and externally well-defended, to be sure (Figures 3.2 and 3.3; see below): its imposing *minar* (Figures 3.5 and 3.6) was one of probably very few monuments per se marking the locality. At the same time, the Bamiyan region (Figures 3.7–3.13) boasts perhaps the broadest array of structures evincing Shansabani-period interventions. But rather than a singular mode of building, Bamiyan and its contiguous valleys encompass an appreciable architectural variety, ranging from reuse and repurposing of pre-existing complexes (Figures 3.9–3.13), to large-scale new constructions (Figures 3.24–3.27). Old Qandahar (Figures 3.28 and 3.29) rounds out the Shansabanis' arc of initial expansion and is even more enigmatic than the other sites: here only funerary mounds can be associated with Shansabani presence.

Although the Chisht, Gharjistan, and Ghazna-Bust region are discussed more thoroughly in Chapters 4 and 5, they merit brief mention here: the nomadic Oghüz had occupied Ghazna and its vicinity for over a decade by the time the Firuzkuh forces effected their momentous victory there in AH 568/1173–1174 CE (see below). But even after this long period of neglect at the old Yamini capital, and likely active deterioration during the nomadic bands' presence, Ghazna and Bust-Lashkari Bazar still presented usable architectural fabrics, which apparently minimized the need for new Shansabani-patronized constructions.[3] It is only in the western and northern directions from Jam-Firuzkuh at Chisht and Gharjistan that the Shansabani presence left behind newly commissioned monumental architecture.

Doubtless, some of the varying methods of making an imperial mark were inflected by the Shansabanis' *pre*-imperial transhumant and/or nomadic beginnings, which continued in modified form into later years (see Chapter 2). These lingering mores surely combined with the exigencies of the occupied territories' own pre-existing landscapes, resulting in a noticeable variety among the early Shansabani annexations. The analyses in Chapters 2–5 of the surviving built remains, then, are essential not only for obtaining a complete picture of the Shansabanis' early imperial expansion; they are equally so for a thorough understanding of the disparate cultural and historical geographies throughout Afghanistan during the twelfth century. Bamiyan, Tiginabad/Old Qandahar, and the outward routes from Jam-Firuzkuh to Chisht, Gharjistan, and Balkh – all integrated to varying degrees within the age-old Khurasani commercial networks radiating in multiple directions from Herat – had each undergone very different developments from the early centuries of the Common Era (and before). These inherited circumstances in turn impacted each of the respective areas' distinct later significances for local and transregional imperial interests well into the second millennium CE. It is worthy of